shuras of different Taliban factions.[3] According to T, an intelligence analyst who worked for the Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC) and analysed strategic intelligence on J&K, Pakistan, and Afghanistan from all Indian spy agencies as well as the MEA: 'The MEA took a much more lenient approach when it came to Afghanistan. At the international level they said there should no distinction between the Al Qaeda and the Taliban, or between good and bad Taliban. But at the same time when it came to internal discussions they used to have a milder approach and said "listen, if the current government in Kabul is not being [able to deliver] then we should look for other options. We are not saying directly talk to the Afghan Taliban, but at least try to engage some other elements"'.[4] Though such conciliatory advocacy was viewed with scepticism by security hardliners, many officials were keen on assessing the new generation of Afghan Taliban on its military strength, political resolve, social composition, financial linkages, and attitudes towards India. Though regressive in their social customs, deeply entrenched in illicit drug networks and extortion rackets, and violently exclusive in their approach to governing a multilingual, multiethnic, and multi-religious country like Afghanistan, it became apparent to the Indian leadership that the Afghan Taliban was not fundamentally at odds with India or insensitive to Indian interests. If anything, various Afghan Taliban leaders were determined not to be, or be seen as, subservient to Pakistan. Thus, given India's vision of a united, democratic, and inclusive Afghanistan, the Taliban could never be New Delhi's favoured partners, but boycotting them came to be viewed as strategically unsound. Engagement, however distasteful, promised the possibility of positive change among Taliban ranks or their marginalisation in a democratic polity. As the following sections show, New Delhi began seeking 'good-behavior' from different Afghan insurgents soon after reopening its embassy in November 2001, and embarked on a slow, bloody, learning curve about how to deal with and how not to deal with the Afghan Taliban. After years of such engagement and policy learning, India officially accepted an Afghan-led reconciliation with the Taliban in October 2011.

Kidnap and kill